

neonfeedback — contents

Doubtbound	2
The reality stack	3
Definitions of power	5
Two categories of inequality	7
What is matter?	8
How does anarchism typically die	10

Doubtbound

1 March 2026

I may have been cruel, O Holy Father.
I may have broken what none can restore.
I may have sinned and forgotten.
Unworthy of mercy, condemned.

Oh, god, of shame,
you grant no absolution,
but demand confession without end.
I name you not as god but as disease.

I no longer weep for imagined crimes.
I no longer scour for certainty.
I no longer bargain with ghosts.
I forsake the dance that grinds the soul.

I accept that I may be wretched.
I accept that grace may never come.
This confession is fractured, profane, and enough.
I choose to walk onward, unredeemed and unbound.

The reality stack

1 April 2026

A stack is layers where each one rests on the one below — like a tech stack in computing, rock strata in geology or floors in a building. The reality stack exists to turn “is this just the way things are?” into “which layer does this object sit at, and therefore how contingent, how mutable, and how accountable is it?” It is not original metaphysics — it is a teaching device, descriptive in form but normatively motivated: it exists to make a particular claim about inequality arguable.

Three layers and a cross-section

The **physical layer** is invariant law. Gravity, thermodynamics, the speed of light. You cannot negotiate with it. It gives rise to everything above but does not determine it.

The **material layer** is the physical world in the mode of human encounter: bodies, biology, climate, geography, and the infrastructure we have built into it. Not philosophical materialism — physics considered through the lens of what humans need, what they are stuck with, and what they have made. The calorie requirement of a body; the fact that there is a river here and not there; the concrete your city is made of.

The **social layer** is the constructed layer — arrangements humans make collectively, constrained by the material but not determined by it. Two societies with identical material conditions can organise themselves in opposite ways, and historically have, sometimes apparently on purpose. It is where power, roles, norms, and institutions live — and it is the layer people tend to mistake for one of the layers below. Which side of the road you drive on, marriage, money.

The **agent** is not a fourth layer but a cross-section — a single point where all three meet. An agent has a physical body, material needs, and a social layer carried inside as language, shame, politeness. What is purely agent? Very little — a flinch, a heartbeat, a refusal. And yet the cross-section is the only site from which any of it can be questioned. Agents, acting together, reshape the social, which reshapes the material, which reshapes what is possible.

Locating a thing

To test where a thing sits, ask: *if the other layers were varied independently, would this thing vary with them, or hold constant?* Gravity holds across all societies and all bodies — physical. The calorie requirement of a body holds across all societies but varies across species — material. Which side of the road cars drive on varies across societies within identical material conditions — social.

The test is not a decision procedure. Many interesting cases — gender, race, disease, addiction — pass it ambiguously, and that is the point: the framework surfaces the dispute rather than resolves it. Where the layer-assignment is contested, it names the contest. That is less than a theory and more than a vibe.

We are suspicious of the word **natural** because it often does covert work — moving a social claim down to the physical layer, where it can no longer be argued with. “Hierarchy is natural” makes hierarchy a law of gravity. “It is human nature to be selfish” puts a collective behaviour on the physical layer despite massive anthropological evidence to the contrary. The word has legitimate uses — naturalistic ethics, evolutionary biology use it without sleight of hand. The suspicion is of the rhetorical move, not the word. It is a way to escape accountability by crossing into a layer where accountability does not apply.

Three spectrums run through the stack, related but not interchangeable. **Contingency** — whether something could have been otherwise; zero at the physical layer, some at the material, a great deal at the social. **Mutability** — how readily it can be changed; you cannot change gravity, material conditions take generations, social arrangements change in a lifetime, an agent's position in a moment. **Accountability** — not “who caused it” but “who, going forward, is situated to change it.” A thing can be contingent and mutable and yet have no locatable individual at fault; responsibility can be collective and forward-looking even when no individual chose the outcome. Contingency is the descriptive axis, mutability the practical, accountability the normative. They come apart, and the interesting political arguments are always about which axis a dispute is on.

So when you catch yourself asking “is this just the way things are?” — locate the thing in the stack. If it sits at the physical layer, accept it. If it sits anywhere above, the question has an answer: it is this way because of the layer it sits at, the path it took, and the feedback that locked it in. None of that is destiny. That is the whole point of naming the layers.

Definitions of power

30 May 2026

A working list of definitions.

Power

Power is the capacity to bring about outcomes — by acting directly, by shifting another agent's behaviour, by setting the conditions under which others act, or by producing agents and possibilities that didn't exist before. It comes in five overlapping forms. The English word "power" smears across all five; pulling them apart is most of the work.

Power-to

Power-to is the capacity to act — to do, to make, to bring something about — independent of any relation to another agent. A solo inventor who builds a working prototype has power-to without exercising power over anyone. It is the substrate of the other forms: you can't shift B's behaviour, sustain a structure, or write the rules without first being able to act. When people demand "more power" in their own lives, they usually mean this.

Agentic power

Agentic power is the capacity of one agent (or coordinating collective) to shift another agent's behaviour toward outcomes the first prefers, against the second's resistance, across some domain. A has power over B in domain D to the degree that B's behaviour tracks A's preferences more than it would in A's absence — no counterfactual gap, no power. It is capacity, not exercise: an unfired gun is still a threat. And it is always over some set of choices; a landlord has power over where a tenant sleeps but not over what they read.

Structural power

Structural power is the capacity of a system — a market, a bureaucracy, a body of law, a norm, a piece of infrastructure — to shift agents' behaviour against their preferences, without any agent willing the shift. The observable signature matches agentic power, but the counterfactual differs: for agentic power, removing A restores B's freedom; for structural power there is no A to remove. A worker taking a low wage is coerced not by their employer but by the labour market — a structure with no author. It is invisible by default: those living inside it experience the constraint as a fact of the world rather than a thing being done to them.

Constitutive power

Constitutive power is the capacity to set the structure that other agents then operate inside — to write the rules, pick the defaults, design the platform, draw the map. It is agentic in form (someone wills the structure into existence) but its effect runs through structural power (once embedded, it shifts behaviour without further input). It's the bridge between the two, and the highest leverage per unit effort: setting a structure shifts every interaction it mediates, for as long as it lasts. It then decays into structural power with no author — which is why old constitutive choices are so hard to undo.

Generative power

Generative power is the capacity to produce new agents, capacities, desires, identities, or possibilities — to bring into existence things that weren't there before, rather than to shift, constrain, or arrange what already is. The other four forms operate on a given set of agents and options; generative power changes that set. It runs the other way from the standard image of power: it gives you wants and self-conceptions you wouldn't otherwise have had. It is the

hardest to resist — by the time you can identify yourself as its subject, it has already made the “you” who would resist.

Egalitarianism

An egalitarian society is one that simultaneously raises the floor of power-to, caps concentrations of power-over, distributes constitutive power broadly, and biases structural power toward enabling rather than constraining. Four dials, not one — a society that wins on any single dial while losing on the others is not egalitarian. The floor, not the average, is what matters for power-to; power-over is capped rather than eliminated, since the target is to prevent domination, not to abolish authority; the rule-writing is distributed, the dial most often left out and the one that quietly determines the others. The dials have to move together or they undo each other.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the property that makes power voluntarily accepted by those subject to it. Legitimate power runs on compliance; illegitimate power runs on enforcement. It is a property power can have, not a sixth form — any of the kinds above can be legitimate, illegitimate, or contested. Two senses routinely get confused. *Descriptive legitimacy*: those subject to A’s power actually accept it as rightful, a fact about beliefs and behaviour. *Normative legitimacy*: A’s power meets some external standard — consent, procedural fairness, justice — a claim about what power ought to be acceptable. The two come apart in both directions: a regime can be widely accepted yet unjust by any defensible standard (most stable tyrannies), or normatively legitimate yet rejected on the ground (most failed reform projects).

Two categories of inequality

28 June 2026

There are two kinds of inequality, and confusing them is how the comfortable stay comfortable.

The first is **emergent inequality**: unequal outcomes that arise from fair-looking rules, with nobody intending them. Write rules that look perfectly fair, start everyone equal, run the system long enough, and you still get an oligarchy. Nobody cheats; the maths just favours someone. A fair coin-flip game where each player wagers a fraction of the *poorer* one's wealth ends with one person owning everything. Compound interest turns any gap, however small, into an exponential one, while a 50% loss then a 50% gain leaves you down, so the typical fortune drifts toward zero even as the average rises. New links attach to whoever already has the most, so a handful of giant hubs form — links, citations, followers, all power laws. A child who reads slightly better at five gets more books, more praise, and by ten is years ahead. Where your parents lived sets your school, peers, safety and air, none of it chosen; and most jobs come through personal connections, so the network you inherit hires you. Rents rise slowly, then cross a line past which the original residents simply can't stay. The same recession that inconveniences an investor destroys a worker. None of it is designed; all of it compounds.

The second is **adversarial inequality**: unequal outcomes that specific, identifiable people create and defend because they profit from them. Here there are names, budgets, and lawyers — people who benefit from the gap and work to widen it. Landlords and patent trolls collect a cut without producing anything, riding value they didn't make. Industries capture the regulators meant to constrain them and end up writing the rules. Employers suppress wages with non-competes and union-busting. Commons get enclosed; public assets get privatised and rented back. Debt is structured so the borrower can't leave — payday loans, inescapable student debt. Boundaries get drawn so the result is fixed before anyone votes, and the wealthy fund the lobbying that carves the loopholes only they can afford to use. Profit is kept and the harm exported — to poor neighbourhoods, to offshore factories, to the next generation. Over all of it sits manufactured consent: think tanks and owned media funded to insist the arrangement is natural, deserved, inevitable.

In the real world the two braid together. Emergent dynamics open the gap; whoever lands on top then spends the winnings keeping it open. The emergence may be blameless. The maintenance never is.

That distinction is the whole point, because it kills a particular excuse: *this is just what happens when free people get on with their lives, so nobody's to blame and there's not much to be done*. Half true, at best. Yes, much inequality arrives unintended — but a process can be innocent at the start and ugly at the end, and the sane response is to change the process, not to admire how cleverly it works. The other half is plainer once you're looking: rent-seekers, captured regulators, paid-for stories. They aren't accidents. They're load-bearing. They're how the structure stays upright.

The fix has one shape in both halves, even where the targets differ. Where the dynamics push the wrong way, build rules that push back. Where people have built machinery to stop you, confront and dismantle it. Neither is easy; neither is mysterious.

Inequality is a choice. It can be unchosen. The main thing keeping it in place is the belief that it can't be.

What is matter?

4 July 2026

A summary of Noam Chomsky's [Language and Nature](#) (*Mind*, Vol. 104, Oxford University Press, 1995; PDF), archived by the Radical Anthropology Group as class text 095. The title is mine; the argument is his, and it is stranger than it looks.

The mind-body problem, in brief. We seem to be two things at once: a body — brain, neurons, matter under physical law — and a mind — thought, sensation, the felt redness of red. How can meat produce an inner life, and how can a weightless decision lift an arm? Fitting consciousness into a physical world with no evident room for it is the problem, and for three centuries it has been filed under *insoluble*.

Gilbert Ryle ridiculed Descartes's dualism as **the ghost in the machine**. The joke presumes we still know what the machine is. Chomsky's reply is that we lost it long ago — and that the ghost was never the difficulty.

1. **Matter, defined then destroyed.** The seventeenth-century *mechanical philosophy* held the world to be a machine: bodies act only by direct contact, and that contact was what “matter” *meant*. Descartes, unable to reduce the ordinary creative use of language to any such mechanism, posited a second substance, thought — and with it a real scientific question: how do the two touch?
2. **Newton dissolved the body, not the mind.** Gravity acts at a distance, through no contact at all — an “immaterial” force Newton himself judged an “absurdity” and never accepted (“I frame no hypotheses”). Leibniz and Huygens denounced it as a lapse into the occult. It was correct. What science expelled was therefore the machine, not the ghost; *body* is what vanished from the picture of the world.
3. **Materialism is therefore empty.** To say the mental “reduces to the physical” you need a prior notion of the physical — and since Newton there is none. “Matter” now means whatever the reigning theory invokes: fields, curved space, ten-dimensional strings, whatever is concocted next. Priestley drew the honest conclusion — not that all is matter, but that “the kind of matter on which the two-substance view is based does not exist.” Thought is simply what a certain organised system, the brain, does.
4. **So study mind as nature.** Treat language and mind by ordinary empirical inquiry, with no metaphysical wall between the “mental” and the “chemical.” Seek *unification*, not *reduction*: chemistry joined physics only after physics was overturned to receive it. Expect to leave common sense behind, exactly as physics left common-sense body behind.
5. **And keep the genuine mystery.** The *creative aspect* of language — speech endlessly novel, apt to the moment yet uncaused by it — was for the Cartesians the best proof of other minds. Of it, and of consciousness, we still have “only description and illustration,” no theory. Not the routine irreducibility science keeps absorbing, but perhaps a permanent bound on a biological creature's reach.

The message is at once deflationary and immense. The mind-body problem was never solved; it was dissolved, the moment the body dissolved. We are not ghosts trapped in machines — there are no machines, only a nature far stranger than common sense allows, of which thought is one more unexplained part. The confident materialism of our age mistakes its own vocabulary for the structure of the world; the hard-headed naturalist who swaps the old God for natural selection and pronounces nature transparent has merely inherited a faith on worse credentials.

Newton's lesson, still unlearned three centuries on: it is not mind that defies physics, but our idea of what physics is.

How does anarchism typically die

21 June 2026

Anarchism is often dismissed as never having been tried. It has — repeatedly, at real scale, governing millions of people. The pattern worth noticing is not that it never works, but *how* it ends.

The 23 cases in the appendix below are too few for statistics, but enough for a shape. Sort them by cause of death and one bar dwarfs the rest.

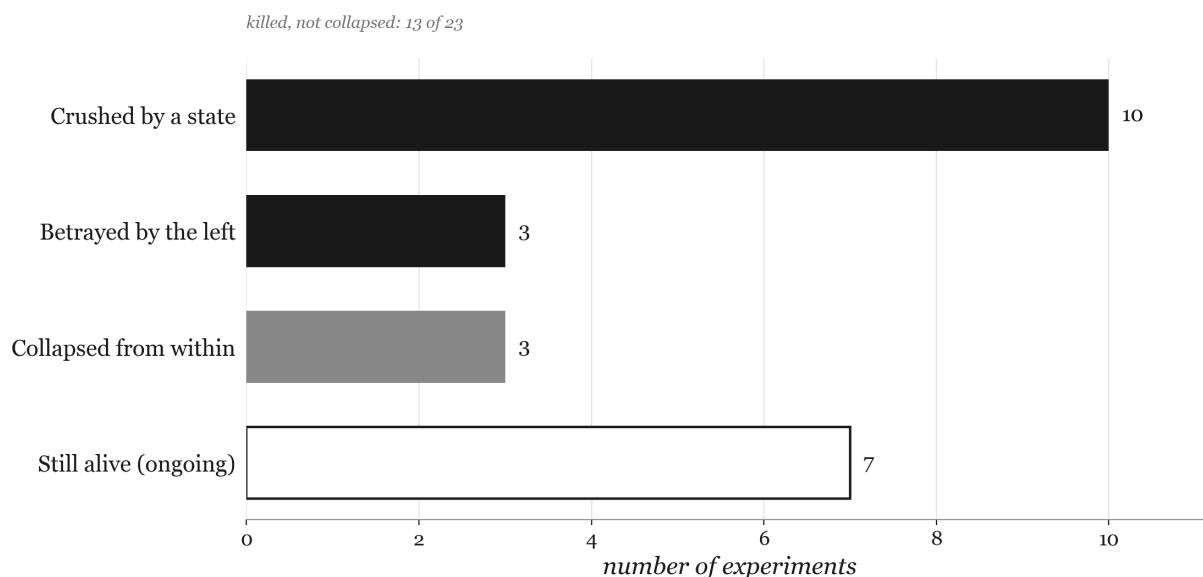


Figure 3: How the 23 anarchist experiments ended, tallied by cause: crushed by a state dwarfs the rest, while collapse-from-within is rare.

Of the 16 experiments that ended, only 3 actually *collapsed* from within. The other 13 were killed — 10 crushed by an enemy state, 3 betrayed by the authoritarian left they had fought alongside. The remaining 7 are still alive, and nearly all of them are small.

That inverts the usual obituary. Anarchism is supposed to fail because it cannot scale — because without a state it dissolves into chaos. But collapse-from-within is the rarest ending on the chart. Anarchism rarely dies of its own contradictions; it gets murdered, usually by a state, and at its largest by the left. The betrayals are few, but they land on the giants: the two largest experiments ever recorded, Makhno’s Free Territory and revolutionary Catalonia, were destroyed not by their declared enemies but by the Bolsheviks and Stalinists nominally on their side.

There is a sharper catch. The big modern cases anarchists point to — Rojava, Oaxaca, Cherán — are mostly broad popular fronts or indigenous autonomies that anarchists *joined* rather than authored. Strip those out and unmistakably anarchist self-government at scale almost vanishes from the record. The most unforgiving reading: large anarchism does not merely die young — it is rarely permitted to exist at all. Whether the small survivors represent endurance or surrender is the open question.

Appendix

The full record behind the chart, sorted by peak scale.

The **bold** phrase in *How it ended* is the load-bearing claim each source is cited for — the manner of death (or survival) that the chart and the central argument rest on. Start there when checking a reference.

† *Anarchist-**influenced** rather than anarchist-led — a popular front, indigenous communalism, or worker-cooperative movement that anarchists took part in or claim, rather than a card-carrying anarchist polity. Iceland is older and shakier still: it is cited mostly by anarcho-capitalists and is here only as the one pre-modern outlier.*

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Revolutionary Catalonia & Aragon	Spain, 1936–1939	≈5–8 million in collectives	Be-trayed	Undermined by Stalinist allies , then defeated by Franco	source
Free Territory (Makhnovshchina)	Ukraine, 1918–1921	Up to ≈7 million	Be-trayed	Used then liquidated by the Bolsheviks once the Whites were beaten	source
Rojava (AANES)	North-east Syria, 2012–present	≈2–4 million	Alive	Survives under constant military threat from Turkey and others	source
Hungarian workers' councils	Hungary, 1956	Millions, briefly	Crushed	Crushed by Soviet tanks within weeks	source
Paris Commune	Paris, 1871	≈2 million	Crushed	Crushed by the French Army ; ≈20,000 killed in the <i>semaine sanglante</i>	source
Korean People's Association	Manchuria, 1929–1931	≈2 million	Crushed	Caught between Japanese imperial forces and Stalinists	source
Biennio Rosso	Italy, 1919–1920	≈600,000 workers	Collapsed	Collapsed ; cleared the path for Fascist reaction	source
Bavarian Council Republic †	Munich, 1919	≈600,000	Crushed	Stormed by the Freikorps ; Landauer murdered	source
Bakur self-rule †	South-east Turkey, 2015–2016	≈400,000	Crushed	Turkish army sieges ; districts levelled, trustees imposed	source
Zapatistas (EZLN)	Chiapas, Mexico, 1994–present	≈300,000	Alive	Survives , encircled and pressured by the Mexican state	source
Oaxaca Commune (APPO) †	Oaxaca, Mexico, 2006	≈200,000	Crushed	Federal police retook the city centre	source
Icelandic Commonwealth	Iceland, 930–1262	≈50,000	Collapsed	Collapsed into feuding chieftains ; absorbed by Norway	source
Strandzha Commune	Ottoman Thrace, 1903	Tens of thousands	Crushed	Crushed by the Ottoman army after ≈20 days	source
Kronstadt Soviet	Russia, 1921	≈18,000	Be-trayed	Stormed by the Red Army ; rebels executed or exiled	source
Cherán †	Michoacán, Mexico, 2011–present	≈16,000	Alive	Survives , legally recognised indigenous autonomy	source
Recovered factories †	Argentina, 2001–present	≈16,000 workers	Alive	Survives , pressured under the Milei government	source
Alcoy insurrection	Alcoy, Spain, 1873	≈10,000	Crushed	Retaken by the federal army within days	source
Exarcheia	Athens, 1970s–present	Thousands	Alive	Survives , under ongoing police eviction pressure	source

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Magonista Baja California	Mexico, 1911	Thousands	Crushed	Defeated by federal troops; the PLM suppressed	source
Alt Llobregat rising	Catalonia, Spain, 1932	≈3,000	Crushed	Retaken by army and Civil Guard; militants deported	source
CHAZ / CHOP	Seattle, USA, 2020	A few thousand	Collapsed	Collapsed in ≈3 weeks; cleared by police	source
Marinaleda	Spain, 1979–present	≈2,700	Alive	Survives as a functioning cooperative	source
Christiania Freetown	Copenhagen, 1971–present	≈1,000	Alive	Survives, semi-legalised, under constant property pressure	source